

A

Types of language and conversation

Some conversations are not serious. They consist of **idle chatter**, in which the speakers just **exchange pleasantries**¹ or share **juicy**² **gossip** about their friends and colleagues, **exchanging news** and **spreading rumours**. **Rumours are always flying around** in any society, of course. But sometimes when you **engage someone in conversation**, it may become more serious. You may **open your heart** to the person you are talking to, for example. You may even find yourself **drawn into an argument**. Some people always want to **win an argument**; for others, **losing the argument** is not important as they simply enjoy a good discussion. If you are in a very noisy place, it can become impossible to **carry on a conversation** of any kind and it is also hard for parents to **hold a conversation** when there are small children in the room.

¹ (formal) make polite conversation

² (informal) interesting because it is shocking or personal

B

Managing topics

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Hi Sophia,

As you know, I wanted to talk to my parents yesterday about my plans for dropping out of university but I didn't have much luck. First of all, I found it very hard to **broach the subject**¹. As soon as I started explaining how badly I wanted to start earning, one of them would **change the subject**. It was as if they were deliberately trying to avoid something they sensed was going to be a problem. Eventually I managed to **bring up the subject** again and they finally started to **take me seriously**. I tried not to **overstate my case**² for leaving and just put things as simply as I could. But then they started to **bombard me with questions**³. Why did I really want to leave? What would I do? Did I realise that I would get a much better job with a degree? Dad didn't listen to my answers – he just started making **broad generalisations** about the importance of education. He went on and on for about half an hour before telling me to **drop the subject** and never refer to it again. So I'm not sure what to do next. Any advice?

Liam

¹ begin a discussion of a difficult topic

³ ask me lots of questions

² give too much importance or seriousness to a point of view

C

Adjective + noun phrases

collocation	example	meaning
bad/strong/foul language	TV dramas today use much more bad/strong/foul language than they did 40 years ago.	swear words, taboo language; <i>foul</i> suggests much stronger disapproval than <i>bad</i> or <i>strong</i>
four-letter words	Please try to express your feelings without using four-letter words .	swear words, taboo words (many of which have four letters in English)
opening gambit	'You're a teacher, aren't you?' was his opening gambit .	a remark made in order to start a conversation
a rash promise	Don't make any rash promises . Think before you agree to anything.	promises made without thinking
an empty promise	She's full of empty promises . You shouldn't believe a word she says.	promises made which the speaker has no intention of keeping
a tough question	Do I regret anything? That's a tough question .	difficult question to answer

Exercises

20.1 Look at A. Correct the collocation errors in these sentences.

- 1 It can be hard to carry out a serious conversation in a noisy room.
- 2 He finds it very difficult to open his head and talk about his feelings to anyone.
- 3 I don't like discussing things with people who always want to gain every argument.
- 4 My mother always used to tell me not to spill unkind rumours.
- 5 I usually find it better not to get driven into an argument with Paul.
- 6 We had a very enjoyable time just sitting in the park enjoying some idling chatter.
- 7 I managed to resist all his attempts to engage me into conversation.
- 8 I've never talked to him much – we've done no more than change pleasantries.

20.2 Complete each sentence using a word from the box in the appropriate form.

bring	broach	drop	hold	lose	strong	take	tough
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- 1 I the argument because I didn't know enough about the subject.
- 2 I think it's time we the subject of our marriage with our parents.
- 3 No one will your ideas seriously unless you present them more effectively.
- 4 My mother can't get used to hearing well-dressed young people using language in public places.
- 5 Whenever I try to up the subject of moving to London, he leaves the room.
- 6 I've said I'm sorry – why can't you just the subject?
- 7 They're sure to ask you some questions at your interview but you can take time to think before you answer.
- 8 I felt so ill last week that I could barely a conversation.

20.3 Match the two parts of these collocations.

- | | |
|---------------|-----------------|
| 1 juicy | promise |
| 2 broad | generalisations |
| 3 exchange | gambit |
| 4 take | question |
| 5 four-letter | seriously |
| 6 tough | word |
| 7 rash | gossip |
| 8 opening | news |

20.4 Rewrite each sentence using the word in brackets.

- 1 Please stop talking about this subject immediately. (DROP)
- 2 Sam has a habit of promising things that he has no intention of doing. (EMPTY)
- 3 You must give due importance to the lab's safety regulations. (SERIOUSLY)
- 4 It's better not to spend too long trying to make your point. (OVERSTATE)
- 5 Could we please start talking about something else? (SUBJECT)
- 6 Did you hear the rumours that people were spreading about your boss last year? (FLYING)
- 7 There are rather a lot of rude words in the play. (LANGUAGE)
- 8 Such general statements tend to be rather meaningless. (BROAD)
- 9 The way he began the conversation took me by surprise. (GAMBIT)
- 10 The children asked me lots and lots of questions about my trip. (BOMBARD)